

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
1. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO CATEGORY		
age terms	<i>a three-year-old</i> <i>a five-year-old child</i> <i>a fifty-five-year-old woman</i> <i>a test for nine-to-ten-year-olds</i> <i>a group of ten- and eleven-year-olds</i> <i>but</i> <i>seven years old</i> <i>eighteen years of age</i>	Hyphenated in both noun and adjective forms (except as in the last two examples); note the space after the first hyphen in the fifth but not the fourth example (see 7.88). The examples apply equally to ages expressed as numerals.
chemical terms	<i>sodium chloride</i> <i>sodium chloride solution</i>	Open in both noun and adjective forms.
colors	<i>emerald-green tie</i> <i>reddish-brown flagstone</i> <i>blue-green algae</i> <i>snow-white dress</i> <i>black-and-white print</i> <i>but</i> <i>his tie is emerald green</i> <i>the stone is reddish brown</i> <i>the water is blue green</i> <i>the clouds are snow white</i> <i>the truth isn't black and white</i>	Hyphenated before but not after a noun.
compass points and directions	<i>northeast</i> <i>southwest</i> <i>east-northeast</i> <i>a north-south street</i> <i>the street runs north-south</i>	Closed in noun, adjective, and adverb forms unless three directions are combined, in which case a hyphen is used after the first. When <i>from . . . to</i> is implied, an en dash is used (see 6.78).
ethnic terms. See proper nouns and adjectives relating to geography or nationality in section 2.		
foreign phrases. See non-English phrases		
fractions, compounds formed with	<i>a half hour</i> <i>a half-hour session</i> <i>a quarter mile</i> <i>a quarter-mile run</i> <i>an eighth note</i>	Noun form open; adjective form hyphenated. See also number entries in this section and half in section 3.

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
1. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO CATEGORY (continued)		
fractions, simple	<i>one-half</i> <i>two-thirds</i> <i>three-quarters</i> <i>one twenty-fifth</i> <i>one and three-quarters</i> a <i>two-thirds</i> majority <i>three-quarters</i> done a <i>one twenty-fifth</i> share	Hyphenated in noun, adjective, and adverb forms, except when second element is already hyphenated. See also number + noun and 9.14.
money	a <i>five-cent</i> raise <i>sixty-four-million-dollar</i> question a deal worth <i>thirty million dollars</i> <i>multimillion-dollar</i> deal but \$30 <i>million</i> loan a \$50-\$60 <i>million</i> loss	For amounts with spelled-out units, hyphenate before a noun but leave open after; where units are expressed as symbols, leave open in all positions, except between number ranges. See also number + abbreviation and 9.20–25, 9.60.
non-English phrases	an <i>a priori</i> argument a <i>Sturm und Drang</i> drama <i>in vitro</i> fertilization a <i>tête-à-tête</i> approach	Open unless hyphens appear in the original language.
number + abbreviation	the 33 <i>m</i> distance a 2 <i>kg</i> weight a 3 <i>ft.</i> <i>high</i> wall a 7 <i>lb.</i> , 8 <i>oz.</i> baby	Always open. See also number + noun .
number + noun	a <i>hundred-meter</i> race a 250- <i>page</i> book a <i>fifty-year</i> project a <i>three-inch-high</i> statuette it's <i>three inches high</i> a <i>one-and-a-half-inch</i> hem <i>one and a half inches</i> a <i>seven-pound, eight-ounce</i> baby a <i>six-foot-two</i> [or <i>six-foot, two-inch</i>] adult <i>six feet two</i> [or <i>six feet, two inches</i> tall] <i>five-to-ten-minute</i> intervals (a single range) but <i>five- or ten-minute</i> intervals (two values)	Hyphenated before a noun, otherwise open. Note the space after the first number in the last example (see 7.88). See also number + abbreviation and 9.13.

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
1. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO CATEGORY (continued)		
number + percent	<i>50 percent</i> a <i>10 percent</i> raise a <i>30–40 percent</i> increase	Noun and adjective forms always open, except between number ranges. See also 9.18, 9.60.
number, ordinal, + noun	<i>third-floor</i> apartment <i>103rd-floor</i> view on the <i>third floor</i> <i>fifth-place</i> contestant <i>twenty-first-row</i> seats in the <i>twenty-first row</i>	Hyphenated before a noun, otherwise open (but see numbers, spelled out). See also century in section 3.
number, ordinal, + superlative	a <i>second-best</i> decision <i>third-largest</i> town <i>fourth-to-last</i> contestant he arrived <i>fourth to last</i>	Hyphenated before a noun, otherwise open.
numbers, spelled out	<i>twenty-eight</i> <i>three hundred</i> <i>nineteen forty-five</i> <i>five hundred fifty-two</i> contestants <i>twenty-eighth</i> <i>three hundredth</i> <i>five hundred fifty-second</i> contestant	Twenty-one through ninety-nine hyphenated; others open. Applies equally to cardinals and ordinals. See also fractions, simple .
relationships. See foster, grand, in-law, and step in section 3.		
time	at <i>three thirty</i> the <i>three-thirty</i> train a <i>four o'clock</i> train the <i>5:00 p.m.</i> news	Usually open; forms such as “three thirty,” “four twenty,” etc. are hyphenated before the noun.
2. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO PARTS OF SPEECH		
adjective + noun	<i>small-state</i> senators a <i>high-quality</i> alkylate a <i>middle-class</i> neighborhood the neighborhood is <i>middle class</i>	Hyphenated before but not after a noun.
adjective + participle	<i>tight-lipped</i> person <i>high-jumping</i> grasshoppers <i>open-ended</i> question the question was <i>open ended</i>	Hyphenated before but not after a noun.

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
2. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO PARTS OF SPEECH (continued)		
adverb ending in <i>ly</i> + participle or adjective	a <i>highly paid</i> ragpicker a <i>fully open</i> society he was <i>mildly amusing</i>	Open whether before or after a noun.
adverb not ending in <i>ly</i> + participle or adjective	a <i>much-needed</i> addition it was <i>much needed</i> a very <i>well-read</i> child <i>little-understood</i> rules a <i>too-easy</i> answer the <i>best-known</i> author the <i>highest-ranking</i> officer the <i>worst-paid</i> job a <i>lesser-paid</i> colleague the <i>most efficient</i> method a <i>less prolific</i> artist a <i>more thorough</i> exam a <i>rather boring</i> play the <i>most skilled</i> workers (most in number) but the <i>most-skilled</i> workers (most in skill) a <i>very much needed</i> addition	Hyphenated before but not after a noun; certain compounds, including those with <i>more, most, less, least</i> , and <i>very</i> , can usually be left open unless ambiguity threatens. When the adverb rather than the compound as a whole is modified by another adverb, the entire expression is open.
combining forms	<i>electrocardiogram</i> <i>socioeconomic</i> <i>politico-scientific</i> studies the <i>practico-inert</i>	Usually closed if permanent, hyphenated if temporary. See 7.82.
gerund + noun	<i>running shoes</i> <i>cooking class</i> <i>running-shoe</i> store	Noun form open; adjective form hyphenated. See also noun + gerund .
noun + adjective	<i>computer-literate</i> accountants <i>HIV-positive</i> men the stadium is <i>fan friendly</i> she is <i>HIV positive</i>	Hyphenated before a noun; usually open after a noun.
noun + gerund	<i>mountain climbing</i> a <i>mountain-climbing</i> enthusiast <i>time-clock-punching</i> employees a <i>Nobel Prize-winning</i> chemist (see 6.80) <i>decision-making</i> <i>head-hunting</i> <i>bookkeeping</i> <i>caregiving</i> <i>copyediting</i>	Noun form usually open; adjective form hyphenated before a noun. Some permanent compounds hyphenated or closed (see 7.82).

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
2. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO PARTS OF SPEECH (continued)		
noun + noun, single function (first noun modifies second noun)	<i>student nurse</i> <i>restaurant owner</i> <i>directory path</i> <i>tenure track</i> <i>tenure-track position</i> <i>home-rule governance</i> <i>shipbuilder</i> <i>gunrunner</i> <i>copyeditor</i>	Noun form open; adjective form hyphenated before a noun. Some permanent compounds closed (see 7.82).
noun + noun, two functions (both nouns equal)	<i>writer-director</i> <i>philosopher-king</i> <i>city-state</i> <i>city-state governance</i>	Both noun and adjective forms always hyphenated.
noun + numeral or enumerator	<i>type A</i> <i>a type A executive</i> <i>type 2 diabetes</i> <i>size 12 slacks</i> <i>a page 1 headline</i>	Both noun and adjective forms always open.
noun + participle	<i>a Wagner-burdened repertoire</i> <i>flower-filled garden</i> <i>the garden was flower filled</i> <i>but</i> <i>the room was air-conditioned</i>	Hyphenated before a noun, otherwise open unless verb form hyphenated in <i>Webster's</i> (see also phrases, verbal).
participle + noun	<i>chopped-liver pâté</i> <i>cutting-edge methods</i> <i>their approach was cutting edge</i>	Adjective form hyphenated before but not after a noun.
participle + up, out, and similar adverbs	<i>dressed-up children</i> <i>burned-out buildings</i> <i>ironed-on decal</i> <i>we were dressed up</i> <i>that decal is ironed on</i> <i>we ironed on the decal</i>	Adjective form hyphenated before but not after a noun. Verb form always open.
phrases, adjectival	<i>an over-the-counter drug</i> <i>a matter-of-fact reply</i> <i>an up-to-date solution</i> <i>sold over the counter</i> <i>her tone was matter of fact</i> <i>his equipment was up to date</i>	Hyphenated before a noun; usually open after a noun.
phrases, noun	<i>stick-in-the-mud</i> <i>jack-of-all-trades</i> <i>a flash in the pan</i>	Hyphenated or open as listed in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in the dictionary, open.

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2. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO PARTS OF SPEECH (continued)		
phrases, verbal	<i>babysit</i> <i>handcraft</i> <i>air-condition</i> <i>fast-talk</i> <i>strong-arm</i> <i>sucker punch</i>	Closed, hyphenated, or open as listed in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in the dictionary, leave open.
proper nouns and adjectives relating to geography or nationality	<i>African Americans</i> <i>African American</i> president a <i>Chinese American</i> <i>French Canadians</i> <i>South Asian Americans</i> the <i>Scotch Irish</i> the <i>North Central</i> region <i>Middle Eastern</i> countries but <i>Sino-Tibetan</i> languages the <i>Franco-Prussian</i> War the <i>US-Canada</i> border <i>Anglo-American</i> cooperation <i>Anglo-Americans</i>	Open in both noun and adjective forms, unless the first term is a prefix or unless <i>between</i> is implied. See also 8.39.
3. COMPOUNDS FORMED WITH SPECIFIC TERMS		
ache	<i>toothache</i> <i>stomachache</i>	Always closed.
all	<i>all out</i> <i>all along</i> <i>all over</i> an <i>all-out</i> effort an <i>all-American</i> player the book is <i>all-encompassing</i> but we were <i>all in</i> [tired]	Adverbial phrases open; adjectival phrases usually hyphenated both before and after a noun.
book	<i>reference book</i> <i>coupon book</i> <i>checkbook</i> <i>cookbook</i>	Closed or open as listed in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in the dictionary, open.
borne	<i>waterborne</i> <i>food-borne</i> <i>mosquito-borne</i>	Closed if listed as such in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in <i>Webster's</i> , hyphenated.

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
3. COMPOUNDS FORMED WITH SPECIFIC TERMS (continued)		
century	the <i>twenty-first century</i> <i>fourteenth-century</i> monastery <i>twenty-first-century</i> history a <i>mid-eighteenth-century</i> poet <i>late nineteenth-century</i> photographs her style was <i>nineteenth century</i>	Noun forms always open; adjectival compounds hyphenated before but not after a noun. See also old (below), mid (in section 4), and 7.87, 9.32.
cross	a <i>cross section</i> a <i>cross-reference</i> <i>cross-referenced</i> <i>cross-grained</i> <i>cross-country</i> <i>crossbow</i> <i>crossover</i>	Many compounds formed with <i>cross</i> are in <i>Webster's</i> (as those listed here). If not in <i>Webster's</i> , leave noun forms open; hyphenate adjective, adverb, and verb forms.
e	<i>email</i> <i>e-book</i> <i>e-commerce</i> <i>eBay</i>	Hyphenated except for <i>email</i> (a departure from previous editions) and certain proper nouns. See also 8.154.
elect	<i>president-elect</i> <i>vice president elect</i> <i>mayor-elect</i> <i>county assessor elect</i>	Hyphenated unless the name of the office consists of an open compound. See also vice .
ever	<i>ever-ready</i> help <i>ever-recurring</i> problem <i>everlasting</i> he was <i>ever eager</i>	Usually hyphenated before but not after a noun; some permanent compounds closed.
ex	<i>ex-partner</i> <i>ex-marine</i> <i>ex-corporate executive</i>	Hyphenated, but use en dash if <i>ex-</i> precedes an open compound (see 6.80).
fold	<i>fourfold</i> <i>hundredfold</i> but <i>twenty-five-fold</i> <i>150-fold</i>	Hyphenated with hyphenated forms of spelled-out numbers or with numerals; otherwise closed.
foster	<i>foster mother</i> <i>foster parents</i> a <i>foster-family</i> background	Noun forms open; adjective forms hyphenated.
free	<i>toll-free</i> number <i>accident-free</i> driver the number is <i>toll-free</i> the driver is <i>accident-free</i>	Compounds formed with <i>free</i> as second element are hyphenated both before and after a noun.

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
3. COMPOUNDS FORMED WITH SPECIFIC TERMS (continued)		
full	<i>full-length mirror</i> the mirror is <i>full length</i> three <i>bags full</i> a <i>suitcase full</i>	Hyphenated before a noun, otherwise open. Use <i>ful</i> only in such permanent compounds as <i>cupful</i> , <i>handful</i> .
general	<i>attorney general</i> <i>postmaster general</i> <i>lieutenants general</i>	Always open; in plural forms, <i>general</i> remains singular.
grand, great-grand	<i>grandfather</i> <i>granddaughter</i> <i>great-grandmother</i> <i>great-great-grandson</i>	<i>Grand</i> compounds closed; <i>great</i> compounds hyphenated.
half	<i>half-asleep</i> <i>half-finished</i> a <i>half sister</i> a <i>half hour</i> a <i>half-hour</i> session <i>halfway</i> <i>halfhearted</i> we <i>half expected</i> to fly	Adjective forms hyphenated before and after the noun; noun and verb forms open. Some permanent compounds closed, whether nouns, adjectives, or adverbs. Check <i>Webster's</i> . See also fractions in section 1.
house	<i>schoolhouse</i> <i>courthouse</i> <i>safe house</i> <i>rest house</i>	Closed or open as listed in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in the dictionary, open.
in-law	<i>sister-in-law</i> <i>parents-in-law</i>	All compounds hyphenated; only the first element takes a plural form.
like	<i>catlike</i> <i>childlike</i> <i>Christlike</i> <i>bell-like</i> a <i>penitentiary-like</i> institution	Closed if listed as such in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in <i>Webster's</i> , hyphenated; compounds retain the hyphen both before and after a noun.
mid. See section 4.		
near	in the <i>near term</i> a <i>near accident</i> a <i>near-term</i> proposal a <i>near-dead</i> language	Noun forms open; adjective forms hyphenated.
odd	a <i>hundred-odd</i> manuscripts <i>350-odd</i> books	Always hyphenated.

Category/ specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
3. COMPOUNDS FORMED WITH SPECIFIC TERMS (continued)		
old	a <i>three-year-old</i> a <i>105-year-old</i> woman a <i>decade-old</i> union a <i>centuries-old</i> debate a child who is <i>three years old</i> the debate is <i>centuries old</i>	Noun forms hyphenated. Adjective forms hyphenated before a noun, open after. See also age terms in section 1.
on	<i>online</i> <i>onstage</i> <i>ongoing</i> <i>on-screen</i> <i>on-site</i>	Sometimes closed, sometimes hyphenated. Check <i>Webster's</i> and hyphenate if term is not listed. See also 7.83.
percent. See number + <i>percent</i> in section 1.		
pseudo. See section 4.		
quasi	a <i>quasi corporation</i> a <i>quasi-public</i> corporation <i>quasi-judicial</i> <i>quasiperiodic</i> <i>quasicrystal</i>	Noun form usually open; adjective form usually hyphenated. A handful of permanent compounds are listed in <i>Webster's</i> .
self	<i>self-restraint</i> <i>self-realization</i> <i>self-sustaining</i> <i>self-conscious</i> the behavior is <i>self-destructive</i> <i>selfless</i> <i>unselfconscious</i>	Both noun and adjective forms hyphenated, except where <i>self</i> is followed by a suffix or preceded by <i>un</i> .
step	<i>stepbrother</i> <i>stepparent</i> <i>step-granddaughter</i> <i>step-great-granddaughter</i>	Always closed except with <i>grand</i> and <i>great</i> .
style	dined <i>family-style</i> <i>1920s-style</i> dancing danced <i>1920s-style</i> <i>Chicago-style</i> hyphenation according to <i>Chicago style</i> <i>headline-style</i> capitalization capitalized <i>headline-style</i> use <i>headline style</i>	Adjective and adverb forms hyphenated; noun form usually open.

Category/specific term	Examples	Summary of rule
3. COMPOUNDS FORMED WITH SPECIFIC TERMS (continued)		
vice	<i>vice-consul</i> <i>vice-chancellor</i> <i>vice president</i> <i>vice-presidential</i> duties a speech that was <i>vice presidential</i> <i>vice admiral</i> <i>viceroy</i>	Adjective forms hyphenated before the noun; noun forms sometimes hyphenated, sometimes open, occasionally closed. Check <i>Webster's</i> and hyphenate if term is not listed.
web	a <i>website</i> a <i>web page</i> <i>web-related</i> matters	Noun form open or closed, as shown; if term is not in any dictionary, opt for open. Adjective form hyphenated. See also 7.80.
wide	<i>worldwide</i> <i>citywide</i> <i>Chicago-wide</i> the canvass was <i>university-wide</i>	Closed if listed as such in <i>Webster's</i> . If not in <i>Webster's</i> , hyphenated; compounds retain the hyphen both before and after a noun.
4. WORDS FORMED WITH PREFIXES		
Compounds formed with prefixes are normally closed, whether they are nouns, verbs, adjectives, or adverbs. A hyphen should appear, however, (1) before a capitalized word or a numeral, such as <i>sub-Saharan</i> , <i>pre-1950</i> ; (2) before a compound term, such as <i>non-self-sustaining</i> , <i>pre-Vietnam War</i> (before an open compound, an en dash is used; see 6.80); (3) to separate two <i>i's</i> , two <i>a's</i> , and other combinations of letters or syllables that might cause misreading, such as <i>anti-intellectual</i> , <i>extra-alkaline</i> , <i>pro-life</i> ; (4) to separate the repeated terms in a double prefix, such as <i>sub-subentry</i> ; (5) when a prefix or combining form stands alone, such as <i>over-</i> and <i>underused</i> , <i>macro-</i> and <i>microeconomics</i> . The spellings shown below conform largely to <i>Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary</i> . Compounds formed with combining forms not listed here, such as <i>auto</i> , <i>tri</i> , and <i>para</i> , follow the same pattern.		
ante	antebellum, antenatal, antediluvian	
anti	antihypertensive, antihero, <i>but</i> anti-inflammatory, anti-Hitlerian	
bi	binomial, bivalent, bisexual	
bio	bioecology, biophysical, biosociology	
cis	cisgender, cissexual, cisatlantic, <i>but</i> cis-Victorian, <i>cis-2-pentene</i> (<i>cis</i> in italics), cis male (<i>cis</i> as adjective)	
co	coequal, coauthor, coeditor, coordinate, cooperation, coworker, <i>but</i> co-op, co-opt	
counter	counterclockwise, counterrevolution	
cyber	cyberspace, cyberstore	

4. WORDS FORMED WITH PREFIXES (continued)	
de	decompress, deconstruct, deontological, <i>but</i> de-emphasize, de-stress
extra	extramural, extrafine, <i>but</i> extra-administrative
hyper	hypertension, hyperactive, hypertext
infra	infrasonic, infrastructure
inter	interorganizational, interfaith
intra	intrazonal, intramural, <i>but</i> intra-arterial
macro	macroeconomics, macromolecular
mega	megavitamin, megamall, <i>but</i> mega-annoyance
meta	metalanguage, metaethical, <i>but</i> meta-analysis (not the same as <i>metanalysis</i>)
micro	microeconomics, micromethodical
mid	midthirties, a midcareer event, midcentury, <i>but</i> mid-July, the mid-1990s, the mid-twentieth century, mid-twentieth-century history
mini	minivan, minimarket
multi	multiauthor, multiconductor, <i>but</i> multi-institutional
neo	neonate, neoorthodox, Neoplatonism, neo-Nazi (<i>neo</i> lowercase or capital and hyphenated as in dictionary; lowercase and hyphenate if not in dictionary)
non	nonviolent, nonevent, nonnegotiable, <i>but</i> non-beer-drinking
over	overmagnified, overshoes, overconscientious
post	postdoctoral, postmodernism, posttraumatic, <i>but</i> post-Vietnam, post-World War II (see 6.80)
pre	premodern, preregistration, prewar, preempt, <i>but</i> pre-Columbian, Pre-Raphaelite (<i>pre</i> lowercase or capital as in dictionary; lowercase if term is not in dictionary)
pro	proindustrial, promarket, <i>but</i> pro-life, pro-Canadian
proto	protolanguage, protogalaxy, protomartyr
pseudo	pseudotechnocrat, pseudomodern, <i>but</i> pseudo-Tudor
re	redit, reunify, reposition, <i>but</i> re-cover, re-creation (as distinct from <i>recover</i> , <i>recreation</i>)
semi	semiopaque, semiconductor, <i>but</i> semi-invalid
sub	subbasement, subzero, subcutaneous
super	superannuated, supervirtuoso, superpowerful

4. WORDS FORMED WITH PREFIXES (continued)

supra	supranational, suprarenal, supraorbital, <i>but</i> supra-American
trans	transgender, transsexual, transmembrane, transcontinental, transatlantic, <i>but</i> trans-American, <i>trans</i> -2-pentene (<i>trans</i> in italics), trans fat (<i>trans</i> as adjective)
ultra	ultrasophisticated, ultraorganized, ultraevangelical
un	unfunded, unneutered, <i>but</i> un-English, un-unionized
under	underemployed, underrate, undercount